

RAJWANT RAWAT

AUTO

SACHIN SRIVASTAVA, 36
Manager with a top auditing firm

SHAIVYA SRIVASTAVA, 34
Manager with an online payments company

Gurugram

What they bought: **Tata Harrier XT+ Dark edition in July 2021**

What they paid: **₹21.5 lakh**

"While looking at the various options, Harrier was available in the ₹18-25 lakh range of on road. We opted for the mid-level variant as we really wanted the sunroof and the black colour, both of which were not available in the base models," says Sachin. They paid an additional ₹2 lakh for these features, along with a plush interior with rear speakers.

nancially secure than their counterparts in the US, Europe and even China, as Deloitte's financial well-being index (see *Positive Sentiment*) shows. The perceived resilience of the Indian economy, in turn, also injected optimism among middle-class youth, many of whom entered the capital markets for the first time during the pandemic. That movement away from old-style thrift is equally visible in consumption patterns: they feel it is perfectly okay to spend their earnings on aspirational products.

That, of course, is preceded by, and predicated on, another trend: a rise in incomes. SBI Research's report 'Deciphering Emerging Trends in ITR Filing: The Ascent of the New Middle Class in Circular Migration' tells us that the average income of Indian taxpayers has grown almost three times from Rs 4.4 lakh in FY13 to Rs 13 lakh in FY22 when read in terms of its weighted mean, led by an increase in the number of tax filers and the transition of several taxpayers from the lower income group to an upper income segment (see *Rising Income*).

Also, unlike their parents, who had to prioritise savings, millennials and Gen Z-ers, particularly those born after the 1990s, have their basic necessities like food, home and health taken care of by their parents. "This sense of security is a very important parameter that was not available to most individuals in the past. This has made them discretionary spenders rather than savers," says Rajeev Singh, partner and consumer industry leader at Deloitte Asia Pacific. And so they are spending like there is no tomorrow. After all, as Harminder Sahni, founder of management consultancy Wazir Advisors, says, "Aspiration is a feeling." Giving in to that feeling are an increasing number of people in India's top 20-25 cities.

Sensing this hunger among consumers for bigger and better goods, manufacturers are vying with each other to put a whole feast of offerings on their plate. The Indian consumer is now spoilt for choice in a variety of products, from automobiles to real estate, consumer durables to fast-moving consumer goods, and even in travel and hospitality.